

REALISTIC FICTION

A New-Found Friend

It was the beginning of the school year and Maria was not happy that Juan was her reading partner. School had only been in session for two weeks and Juan had already made fun of her glasses and her blue shoes. Maria told Mrs. Damian, her sixth-grade teacher, about these rude interactions in hopes of switching reading partners.

Unfortunately, Mrs. Damian told Maria that Juan would remain her partner for the realistic fiction unit.

Still feeling upset about having to work with Juan, Maria avoided eye contact with him when he walked into their room after recess. Until, thud! When Maria heard this loud noise, she looked up to see that all of Juan's books had fallen out of his backpack. Juan's face turned bright red as he bent down to pick up the mess. Maria rushed over to him. Despite Juan's rude behavior to her during the first two weeks of school, Maria helped Juan pick up his books and said, "No worries, Juan, isn't it hard to have to lug all of these books around?"

That afternoon during their reading partnership, Juan thanked Maria for her kind gesture. He even mentioned that the ideas she shared that day helped him to think of literary reflections. Maria realized she was learning a lot from Juan, too. As the realistic fiction unit came to a close, Maria and Juan both realized that they learned a great deal from each other and had even found a new friend.

The Good Samaritan

A certain man traveling down from Jerusalem to Jericho fell among thieves on the way. They took his clothes away and wounded him, leaving him half-dead. By chance, a Jewish priest passed by and saw the man but did not stop. A Levite passed by him and he too, did not stop. A certain Samaritan journeyed and stopped when he saw the half-dead man. He went down and treated his wounds, pouring on it oil and wine. Then he brought him to an inn and took care of him. When the Samaritan left, he gave some money to the inn keeper and asked him to take care of the wounded man and if there are still expenses to be paid, the Samaritan would pay him when he gets back.

In Memory of Frankie

Frankie was a pet turtle given to the author as a birthday gift. After researching online, the author discovered that Frankie was a Hawksbill turtle, an endangered species threatened by hunting, pollution, and fishing nets. The author also learned that Hawksbill turtles play an important role in maintaining the balance of the marine ecosystem.

Wanting what was best for Frankie, the author contacted the World Wildlife Fund and decided to donate him so he could live in a safe environment and help increase the population of his species. Although the author was sad to say goodbye, the experience taught the importance of protecting endangered animals and inspired the author to help conserve wildlife.

Thank You, Ma'am

Late one night, a large woman named Mrs. Luella Bates Washington Jones was walking home when a boy named Roger tried to steal her purse. Instead of letting him escape, she caught him, picked him up, and asked why he tried to rob her. Roger admitted that he wanted money to buy a pair of blue suede shoes.

Mrs. Jones took Roger to her home instead of calling the police. She told him to wash his face and prepared a simple meal for both of them. While they ate, she talked kindly to him and shared that she had also made mistakes when she was young. Roger realized that she trusted him because she left her purse where he could have taken it, but he chose to stay.

Before Roger left, Mrs. Jones gave him ten dollars to buy the shoes he wanted. She reminded him never to steal again because it was the wrong way to get what he wanted.

ELEVEN

Rachel is excited because it is her eleventh birthday. She believes that even though she is eleven, she still carries the feelings of all the ages she has been before. Sometimes she feels ten, five, or even three years old.

During class, Mrs. Price holds up an old red sweater and asks whose it is. No one claims it, but a classmate says it belongs to Rachel. Even though Rachel quietly says it is not hers, Mrs. Price does not believe her and places the sweater on Rachel's desk.

Rachel feels embarrassed because the sweater is old, ugly, and smells bad. She pushes it away, hoping to get rid of it. Later, Mrs. Price tells Rachel to put the sweater on. Rachel obeys, but she feels so upset that she begins to cry in front of the whole class.

Just before lunch, another student remembers that the sweater actually belongs to her. Rachel quickly gives it back, but the damage has already been done. Although it is her birthday and there will be cake and presents at home, Rachel no longer feels happy. She wishes she were much older so she would have known how to handle the situation better.

The Marble Champ

Lupe Medrano was an excellent student. She won spelling bees, reading contests, science fairs, and chess competitions. However, she was not good at sports. She could not run fast, catch a ball, or ride a bike without training wheels. She wished she could win something athletic.

One day, Lupe decided to enter the school marbles championship. She practiced every day by strengthening her thumb, improving her aim, and learning techniques from her brother. She worked hard for weeks without giving up. Her parents supported and encouraged her after seeing how determined she was.

On the day of the competition, Lupe won her first matches and advanced to the finals. Her last opponent was a skilled player, and the game was very close. Despite feeling nervous and having dust blow into her eyes, Lupe stayed focused. She trusted her practice, made the winning shot, and became the marbles champion.

After the tournament, Lupe also defeated the boys' champion. She received two trophies, and her family celebrated her success with a pizza dinner. At home, Lupe proudly placed the trophies on her shelf. For the first time, she had won not because of her intelligence, but because of her hard work, determination, and perseverance.

Two Were Left

(Retold)

by Hugh B. Cave

On the third night of hunger, Noni thought of the dog. Nobody lived upon the floating land except himself and the dog.

When the ice broke up, Noni had lost his sled, his food, his furs, even his knife. He had saved only Nimuk, his great devoted husky. And now the two, marooned on the ice, eyed each other warily each keeping his distance.

Noni's love for Nimuk was real. But the men of this village killed their dogs when food was scarce.

Noni told himself that Nimuk, when hungry enough would begin to seek food. "One of us will soon be eating the other," Noni thought. "So.."

He could not kill the dog with his bare hands. Nimuk was powerful and much fresher than he. A weapon, then, was needed.

Removing his mittens, he unstrapped the braces from his injured leg. When he had hurt his leg a few weeks before, he had made the brace from bits of harness and two thin strips of iron.

Kneeling now, he wedged one of the iron strips into a crack in the ice. Then, he began rubbing the other against it with firm, slow strokes.

Nimuk watched him, and it seemed to Noni that the dog's eyes glowed more brightly.

He worked on, trying not to remember why. The slab of iron had an edge now. It had begun to take shape. By daylight, his task was completed. He had finished making a knife!

Noni pulled the finished knife from the ice and felt its edge. The sun's glare reflected from it. Its brightness stabbed at his eyes and momentarily blinded him.

Noni forced himself to call the dog.

"Here, Nimuk!" he called softly.

The dog suspiciously watched him.

"Come here, " Noni called.

Nimuk came closer. Noni read fear in the animal's gaze. He read hunger and suffering in the dog's labored breathing and awkward crouch. He hated himself and fought against it.

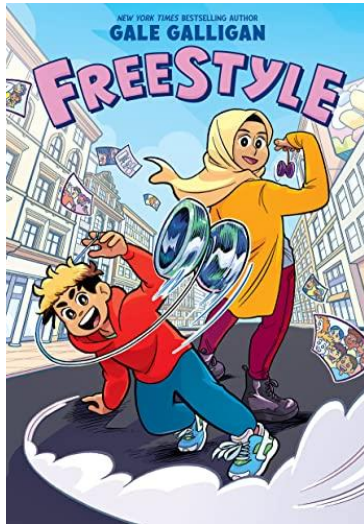
Closer Nimuk came, aware of Noni's intentions. Now Noni felt a thickening in his throat. He saw the dog's eyes, and they were wells of suffering. Now! Now was the time to strike! A great sob shook Noni's kneeling body. He cursed the knife. He swayed blindly, flung the weapon far away from him. With empty hands outstretched, he stumbled toward the dog and fell.

The dog growled as he circled the boy's body. And now Noni was sick with fear. In flinging away the knife, he had left himself defenseless. He was too weak to crawl after it now. He was at Nimuk's mercy, and Nimuk was hungry.

The dog had circled him and was creeping up from behind. Noni heard the rattle in the animal's throat. He shut his eyes, praying that the attack might be swift. He felt the dog's feet against his leg, the hot rush of Nimuk's breath against his neck. A scream gathered in the boy's throat. Then, he felt the dog's hot tongue licking his face. Noni's eyes opened. Crying softly, he thrust out an arm and drew the dog's head down against his own.

The plane came out of the south an hour later. Its pilot, a young man of the coast patrol, looked down and saw the large floating iceberg. And he saw something flashing. He became curious so he circled and flew lower his seaplane. Now, he saw, in the shadow of the peak of ice, a dark, still shape that appeared to be human. Or were there two shapes?

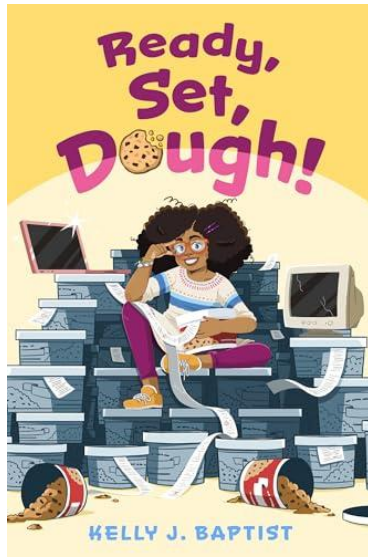
He set his seaplane down on the water lane and found a boy and a dog. The boy was unconscious but alive. The dog whined feebly but was too weak to move. The gleaming object which had caught the pilot's attention was a crude knife. It was stuck, point down, into the ice a short distance away, and quivering in the wind.



Freestyle

By Gale Galligan (Author)

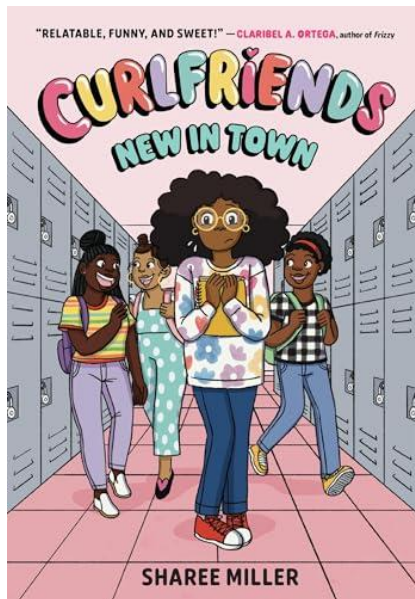
Cory's dance crew is getting ready for a major competition. It's the last one before they graduate eighth grade and go their separate ways to high schools all over New York City, so they have to make it count! The group starts to have problems as their crew captain gets increasingly intense about nailing the routine, and things go from bad to worse when Cory's parents ground him for not taking his grades seriously. He gets stuck with a new tutor, Sunna, who he dismisses as a boring nerd... until he catches her secretly practicing cool yo-yo tricks. Cory wants to learn the art of yo-yo, and as his friendship with Sunna grows, he ends up missing practice and bailing on his crew — and they are not happy about it. With mounting pressure coming from all sides, how is Cory supposed to balance the expectations of his parents, school, dance, and his new friend? This is a fun graphic novel about dance, friendships, and balancing it all.



Ready Set Dough

By Kelly J. Baptist (Author)

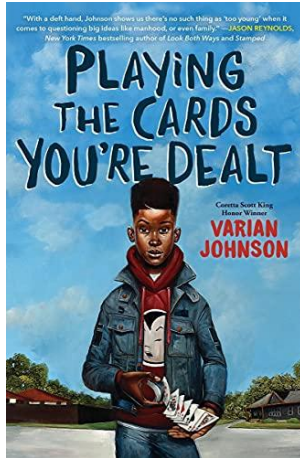
Ambitious sixth grader Zoe Sparks loves to write and enjoys brainstorming ideas for her journalism class. There's only one problem: Her at-home computer is so unreliable that it just stops working one day. Fortunately, her school is organizing a cookie dough fundraiser, and guess what the top seller prize is? A WordPro laptop — and orange (her favorite color) at that! Zoe is determined to outsell everyone, especially her nemesis Amaya. But soon, her ambition begins to impact her balance and her friendship with her BFF Felix. I adored the voice in this one and finished it in one day.



Curlfriends: New in Town

By Sharee Miller (Author)

Charlie is the new kid for the umpteenth time, but this time things will be different. Her dad is no longer in the military, and this is a more permanent home, so she feels more pressure to find and impress some new friends. When she meets a cool group of Black girls with varying interests, she decides to hide her “babyish” style and hobbies to befriend them. But she soon learns that with true friends, you can be your whole self. *Curlfriends: New In Town* is the cute first book in a new graphic novel series about Black hair, girlfriends, fashion, and adjusting to change.



Playing the Cards You're Dealt

By Varian Johnson (Author)

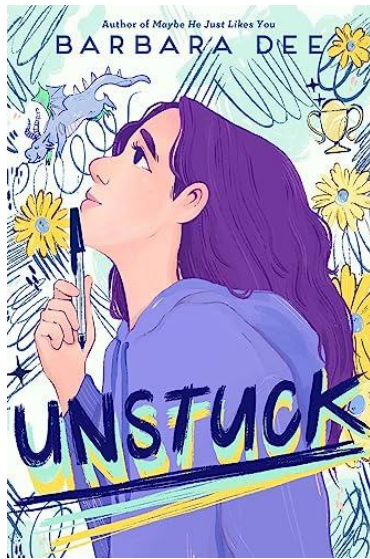
Ant isn't your average 10 year old. He loves a good game of spades and he and his best friend are planning to revamp their reputation after losing badly at the last spades tournament. But things are changing in Ant's life. His dad is acting weird, asking him to hide things from his mom. There's a new girl in class who Ant maybe likes and who plays spades better than many boys he knows. When his best friend is grounded, Ant teams up with Shirley, hoping to impress his father and finally be tough like Joplin men should be. But instead, he learns what it really means to be a man—and it's not about never crying. There's SO MUCH going on in this story, but the author does a stunning job of keeping all the threads in place. I was very surprised by all the protagonist has to manage at his age and the fact that it all remains believable. The story is told by Ant's ancestor, lending a touch of magic realism. There are also many details about playing a game of spades and I loved, loved the audiobook narrator.



Light and Air

By Mindy Nichols Wendell (Author)

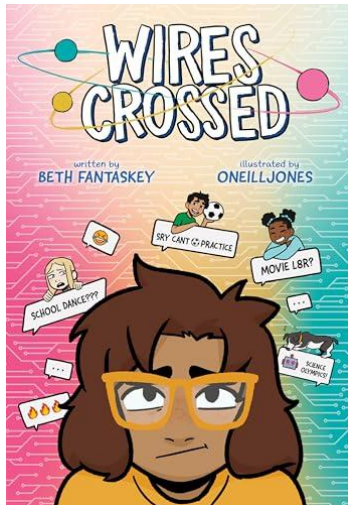
As a non-fan of historical fiction, I was pleasantly surprised by this debut middle grade novel. Set in 1930s New York, where a tuberculosis epidemic is raging, it follows Halle, whose mother is diagnosed with the disease and sent off to JN Adams Sanatorium in Perrysburg. There, everyone, including people of all races, is welcome, and patients are treated with exposure to light and air. Soon, Halle ends up there to treat pneumonia. This book is accessible, plain-spoken, and truly written for kids without dumbing down or info dumping. The characters are richly drawn, and the subject matter is intriguing and rarely explored in books for kids. It's impressive that the author has created a book all about tuberculosis with a rich, moving, adventurous, and tender plot balancing friendship, family, mystery, and history all at once.



Unstuck

By Barbara Dee

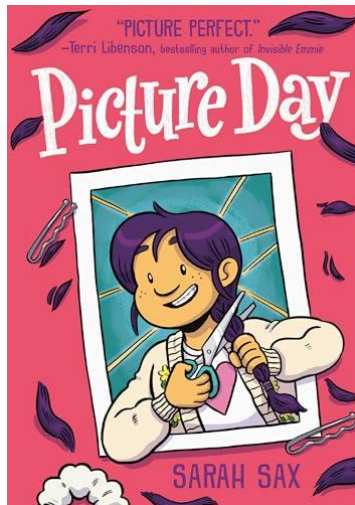
Lyla is an overlooked second child with a big sister who seems perfect — smart, beautiful, favored by her parents, and socially adept. In contrast, Lyla has one best friend, Rania, from whom she's been separated and who seems to be expanding her social circle without Lyla. Lyla believes her main identity is a WRITER, but as a seventh grader, she's looking to impress Ms Bowman, her new creative writing teacher whom she admires, and also Rania, who seems to be drifting away. With all the pressure, despite having a brilliant fantasy story idea, Lyla is stuck with writer's block. As she navigates, admitting to the problem, writing for the joy of writing (not awards or impressing people), she also begins to build a new friend network. This is such a fresh take on writing anxiety — something many kids are dealing with. The back matter features 25 tips from the author for getting unstuck. *Unstuck* will be great for kids who love writing, are dealing with school social caste systems, and are finding their place in their families.



Wires Crossed

By Beth Fantaskey (Author),

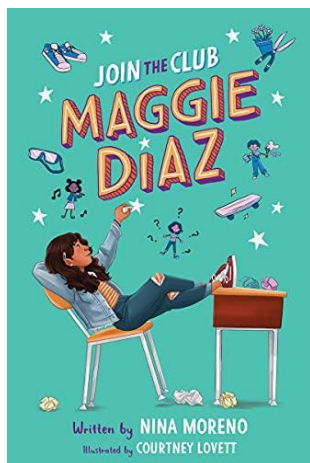
13-year-old Mia feels like her social circle is changing faster than she can keep up with. Her best friend Addy is now friends with a not-nice popular girl whom they were both united in not liking. In a positive twist of events, one of her good friends, Tariq, whom she knows from science camp, announces that he's moving to her town. But when Tariq arrives, he looks different: cool haircut, contacts, and he plays sports too now? Tariq quickly begins to make friends at school while remaining friends with Mia, who also finds herself befriended by Kinsey, a nice but mysterious girl in her class. Soon, Kinsey, Tariq, Mia, and another kid, Evan, get thrown into a science lab group together, and their first project is building a snake robot. This is another slice-of-life graphic novel for fans of Telgemeier's books, and the friendship miscommunications add a necessary level of tension and suspense. I also loved the friendship between these kids and the fact that everything stays platonic (which is rare in kidlit these days).



Picture Day

By Sarah Sax (Author)

Middle schooler Viv is tired of being boring and ordinary. She wants to amass social media followers and be a trendsetter like some of her classmates. She also watches a YouTuber who encourages her inclinations. So, on picture day, she gets the grand idea to chop off her pigtail, creating a strange hairstyle, which a hairstylist eventually refines into something more attention-grabbing. Suddenly, everyone wants Viv's advice, and she becomes more pushy too, especially towards her friends. It's not long before everything comes crashing down. This is a funny but thoughtful start to a new graphic novel series for fans of the *Click* Series.



Join the Club, Maggie Diaz

By Nina Moreno (Author), Courtney Lovett (Illustrator)

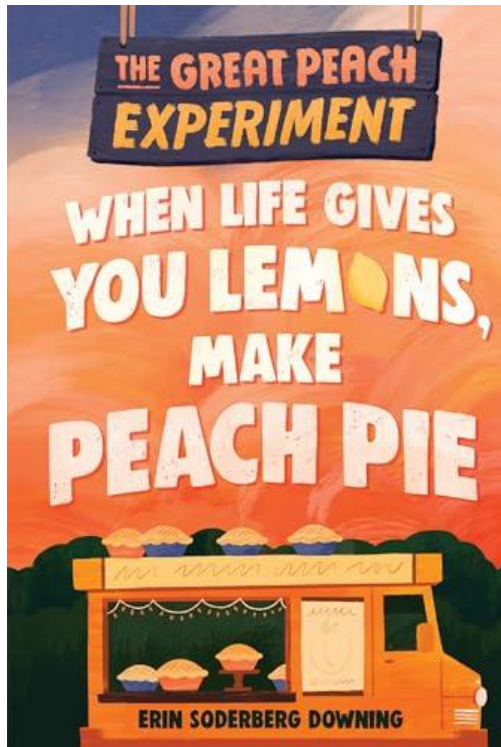
New seventh-grader Maggie Diaz is not the most organized person. But she's trying to become her best self this school year so she can win her parents' trust and get a new phone by the end of the year. She soon finds out that getting on honor roll is not that easy. Worse still, Maggie's dealing with so many changes. Her best friends have joined after-school clubs to pursue their interests and have little or no time for Maggie (who can't seem to find her interests). This is a lively, engaging debut about finding your place and passions when everyone else seems to be miles ahead in the game. Content note: Maggie discovers that her sister is dating a girl.



A Place to Hang the Moon

By Kate Albus (Author)

A Place to Hang the Moon follows three orphaned kids in England during the WWII evacuation. Orphans William, Edmund, and Anna (aged 12, 11, and 9) are evacuated after their (not nice) grandmother dies. The kids are instructed not to disclose how well off their family is until they're placed with a new family that feels like a forever family. In their new countryside dwelling, the kids are placed with several poorly matched families. The first family has twin boys who are just horrid and the second family is too poor (and could care less about them besides the money she's paid to look after them). Through it all, the children take solace in each other, stories from William about their parents, and their love of books and the town library. This is a heartwarming, immersive middle-grade debut.



The Great Peach Experiment #1: When Life Gives You Lemons, Make Peach Pie

By Erin Soderberg Downing (Author)

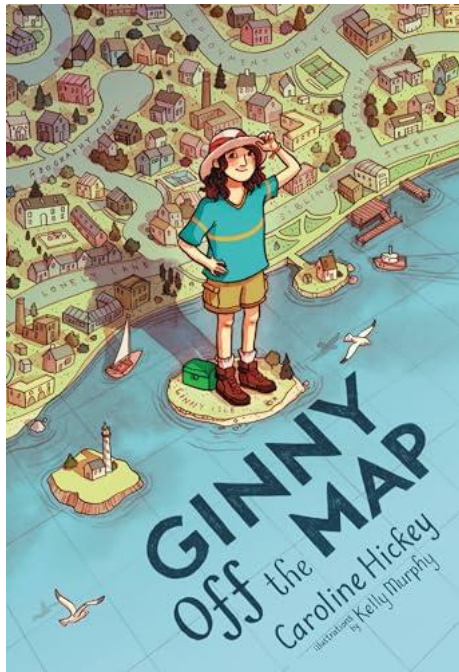
Lucy, Freddie, and Herb have spent more time with each other than with their father since their mom died. But now one of their mom's inventions has sold for a lot of money, and their dad has bought a food truck and wants them to spend the summer traveling through the country as a family. The kids are hesitant at first, but Freddie is glad to miss summer school, so he gets on board super quickly. Firstborn and watchdog of her siblings, Lucy is suspicious but agrees because she wants her dad to be more present in their lives. Herb is just happy as long as he gets to swim every single day while they're on the road. The family plans to also enter a food truck contest at the end of their trip to compete for \$10,000. But along the way, they learn a lot about what really matters. This is a wonderful introduction to a new middle-grade series for fans of *The Vanderbeekers*.



I Am Kavi

By Thushanthi Ponweera (Author)

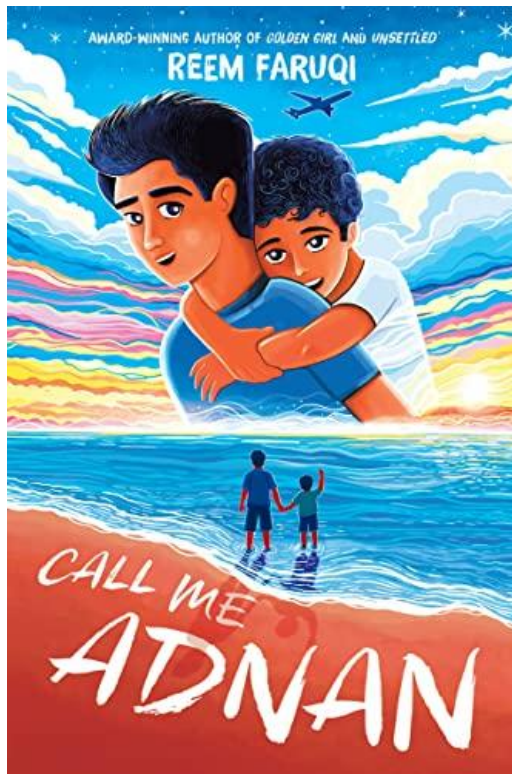
It's 1998 in Colombo, Sri Lanka. In the middle of the Sri Lankan Civil War, Kavi is dealing with her own personal upheavals. Her mother has remarried her father's best friend after his death and is expecting a new baby. Meanwhile, Kavi is getting sent to the city on a scholarship to an elite private school. There, she starts telling lies about a life of wealth and grandeur—small at first, then bigger and bigger—to fit in with the rich kids until she begins to lose herself. This is a touching verse novel about a young girl adapting to changes in her world and finding her voice amidst the Sri Lankan civil war.



Ginny Off the Map

By Caroline Hickey (Author)

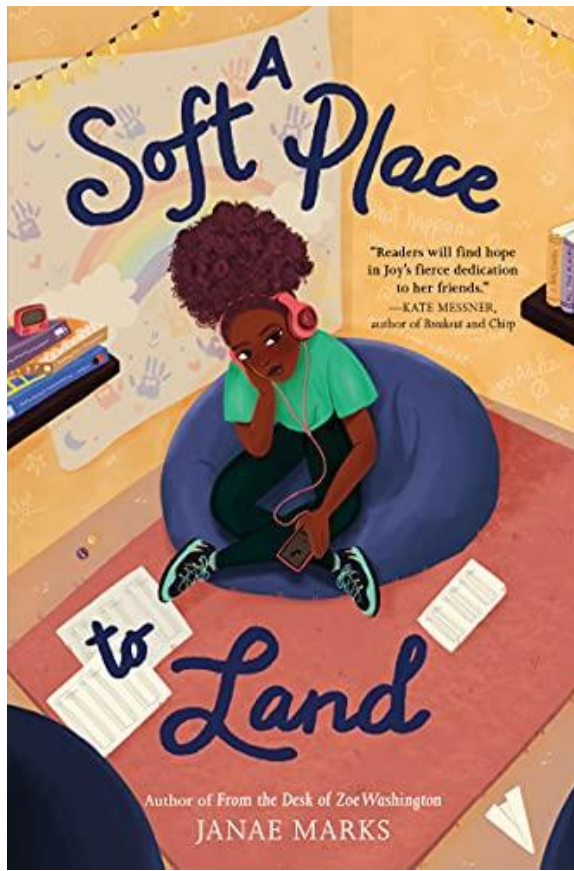
Ginny's summer is thrown off when her dad gets a surprise redeployment in the middle of their family's moving to another city. Then, her geography camp gets canceled. Her sister seems to be making new friends, but no one appears to like Ginny—even when she starts her own geography camp. This sweet, unique young middle grade book made my heart grow and ache for Ginny and her family as they navigated a season of change. Features illustrations and a new geography fact in each chapter.



Call Me Adnan

By Reem Faruqi (Author)

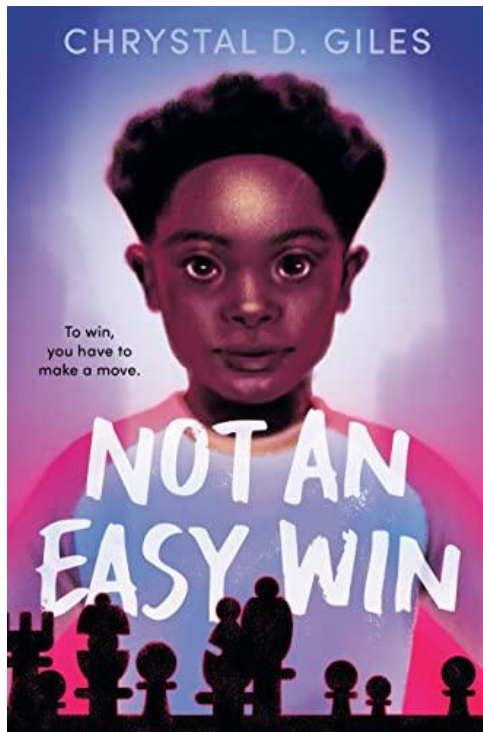
Adnan loves table tennis, his family, and the aviation alphabet. He's color blind, left-handed and has a big sister and little brother, with another sibling on the way. When his family take a summer trip so he can compete in a tennis tournament, an unbelievable tragedy occurs, shattering their life as they know it. I don't like sad stories. Life is hard enough, but the author drew me into this story and I couldn't stop reading. The verse format is enjoyable and provides a wide enough window into the plot and characters. Most importantly, this story is very hopeful, despite the tragedy. If you love verse novels and don't mind a tearjerker, this is a perfect summer story for you. Heads up for sibling loss and child drowning.



A Soft Place to Land

By Janae Marks (Author)

Joy Taylor and her family have moved into an apartment complex because her dad lost his job, and their mortgage is too expensive to keep on one income. Now Joy has to share a room with her little sister and hear her parents fight every day about the work her dad chooses (or chooses not to do). Her only respite is the nice kids in the building and the hideout they introduce Joy to. One of the kids befriends Joy and they even start a dog-walking business together. But when Joy finds a sad message on the hideout wall, she's determined to find out the person in need, but her good intentions cause more harm than good. This is a sweet, heartfelt story about finding friendship and community and handling financial difficulties as a family.



Not An Easy Win

By Chrystal D. Giles (Author)

In *Not an Easy Win*, young Lawrence has had the odds stacked against him for so long. He and his mom and little sister went from living in Charlotte, NC to finally moving in with his grandma while his father is incarcerated. To make matters worse, Lawrence keeps getting picked on at school and getting into fights which results in his getting expelled. While he's home, he starts going to the town's rec center where he learns to play chess. But a boy there keeps trying to get Lawrence to fight. Can he find a way to secure a win for once? *Not an Easy Win* is a heartwarming, realistic, and satisfying book about poverty, having an incarcerated parent, and finding belonging in chess.

